Lesson 3 · Lock down your phone · for your pupils

Phone safety clinic

40 minutes | Ages 10–16 · adapt for other ages below | No electricity needed | No devices needed | Photocopy-friendly

Big question

How can we keep a phone, and what's on it, safe?

Pupils will be able to...

- Name six habits that keep a phone safe.
- Choose the right fix for a phone safety problem and explain why.
- Explain why a lock code like 1234 or a birthday is unsafe.

You need

- Board and chalk, or a large paper phone drawing
- 12 problem cards on scrap paper (see prep)
- A paper or cardboard phone for the role-play
- Worksheet: Phone check-up (one per pair, optional)

Before class

Draw a large phone on the board with six icons around it: padlock, update arrow, store bag, eye, map pin, backup box. Write 12 problem cards, such as "My code is 1234", "A game wants my messages" and "I lost my phone".

Time	What you do	What you can say	Pupils
Warm-up 0–5 min	Ask what is on a family phone that a stranger shouldn't see or use. List answers on the board: photos, messages, mobile money, contacts.	*"If a stranger picked up this phone, what could they see or do?"*	Name things a phone holds; see why it needs protecting.
Teach 5–13 min	Walk through the six icons. For each, give one sentence and one risky example: 1234, an app sent in a chat, a torch app wanting contacts, no backup.	*"Lock it, update it, use the official store, check permissions, turn on find my device, back it up."*	Repeat the six habits with a hand action for each.
Phone clinic 13–27 min	Pairs take turns: one is the phone owner with a problem card, the other is the "phone doctor" who points to an icon and explains the fix. Swap after each card. Walk around and listen.	*"Doctor, which icon fixes this problem — and why?"*	Role-play owner and doctor; choose and explain a fix.
Share 27–34 min	Three pairs act out their trickiest card for the class. The class votes on the fix with thumbs up or down.	*"Do we agree with the doctor? Would another setting help too?"*	Watch, vote and suggest other fixes.
Wrap-up 34–40 min	Exit ticket: pupils draw one icon and write the habit it stands for. Suggest they check one setting on a family phone with an adult tonight.	*"Tonight, ask an adult at home if their phone has a strong lock and a backup."*	Complete the exit ticket; plan a check at home.

Check understanding
Listen for reasons, not just icons: “because 1234 is guessed first”, “because the store checks apps”. If a pupil picks the wrong icon, ask: “What is the problem trying to steal or break?”

Exit ticket
Draw one phone safety icon and write the habit it stands for.

Common mix-ups

Pupils may think…	Help them see…
Updates only add new features.	Many updates fix security holes. It’s like mending a broken window, not buying new curtains.
My birthday makes a secret code.	Lots of people know your birthday — friends, classmates, social media. Pick numbers with no link to you.
An app from a friend is safe.	Friends can pass on harmful apps by accident. Install only from the official store, with an adult’s OK.

Adapt it

Younger pupils
Ages 6–9: focus on two habits — a secret lock code, and asking an adult before installing any app. Use a paper phone and act it out.

Older pupils and university
Pupils list what five familiar apps should be allowed to use, then design a one-page phone safety poster for the school notice board.

Large classes
Read problem cards aloud. Rows act as doctors: the first row to name the right icon and a reason wins a point.

No board or no space
Draw the phone and icons on the ground with a stick, or on a large sheet of paper passed between groups.

Short on time? Do the teach step and six problem cards as a whole-class clinic (20 minutes).

What you need to know

Your phone holds your email, mobile money, photos and parents’ numbers. A few settings — a strong lock, updates, safe apps, “find my device” and backups — protect all of it.

Screen lock
A PIN, pattern, password, fingerprint or face check that must be passed before anyone can use your phone.

App permission
What an app is allowed to use on your phone, such as the camera, microphone, contacts, location or messages.

Update
A free improvement from the phone or app maker. Many updates fix security holes that criminals could use to get in.

Backup
A copy of your photos and contacts kept somewhere else — online or on a computer — so they survive if your phone is lost or broken.

My notes — how did it go?